

GTALES PARENT GUIDE 01 · ANGER & HITTING

When Feelings Run Hot

What is happening when your child explodes, why it happens, and what actually helps, based on child-development research.

Green = calm · Yellow = getting hot · Red = overload

The guide in 60 seconds

1. Tantrums are common: more than 80% of preschoolers have them. Daily or destructive ones are not, and those are worth a closer look.
2. The hidden cause is often the body. About 6 in 10 preschoolers had a tantrum when tired, hungry or sick, almost as many as when frustrated.
3. Calm, predictable limits work. Spanking and shouting make aggression worse.

First, take a breath

If your child hits, throws or screams, it does not mean you have failed, or that something is wrong with them. Anger is a normal, healthy feeling. Hitting is a missing skill, and skills can be taught.

PART 1

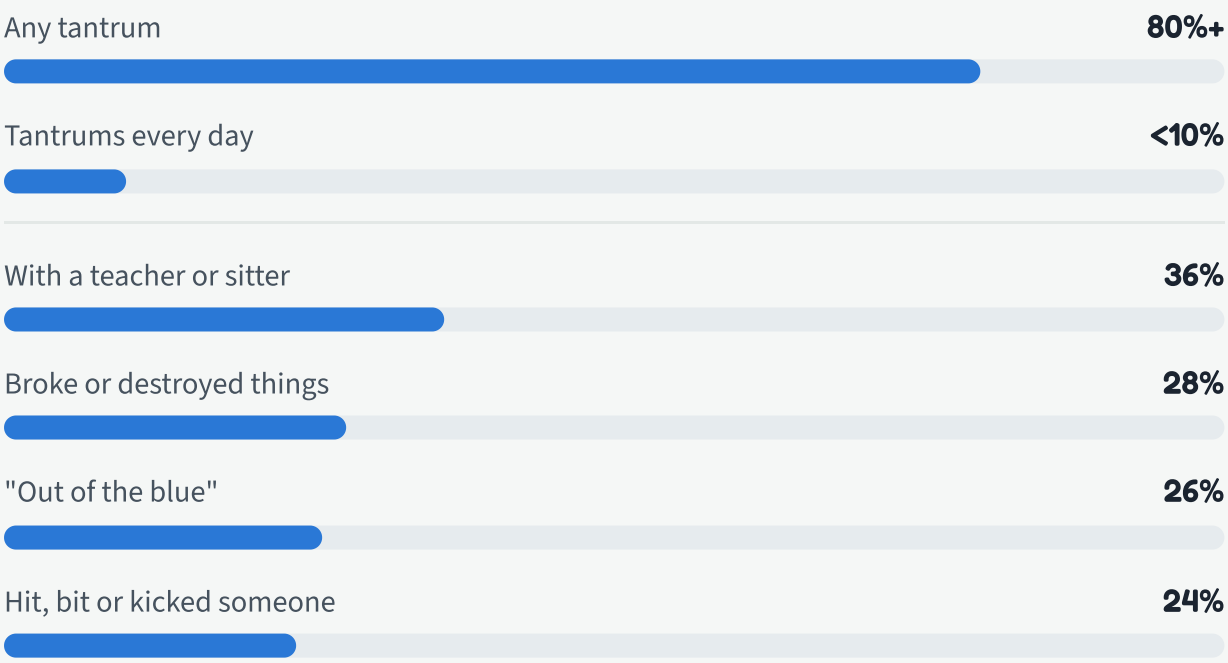
Understanding anger

Anger is the body's alarm. It goes off when something feels unfair, blocked or threatening. In young children it fires fast, before the thinking part of the brain can catch up.

Self-control, planning and "stop-and-think" skills grow slowly across childhood. A 5-year-old often knows hitting is wrong and still cannot stop in the moment. That is not defiance. The brakes are simply not fully built yet.

Tantrums are common. Daily or destructive ones are not.

Share of preschoolers (ages 3–5) whose parents reported each behavior in the past month. About 1,500 families.



Source: NIMH, 2012 (Wakschlag et al.). The first two bars are reported as "more than 80%" and "fewer than 10%".

Most young children hit sometimes

572 children followed from 17 to 42 months, grouped by how much physical aggression mothers reported.



Little or none	28%
Some, modest	58%
High and rising	14%

Source: Tremblay et al., 2004, Pediatrics. Most children use their hands less as words and self-control grow; the small high group is where extra support matters most.

What it looks like at each age

Age 4–5

WHAT IS COMMON

Tantrums, hitting, biting, throwing when blocked or told no. Calms down faster with an adult's help.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Whining, red face, stiff body, grabbing.

Age 6–7

WHAT IS COMMON

Shouting "That's not fair!", slamming doors, hitting siblings, sulking. Starting to use words, but not under pressure.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Clenched fists, louder voice, stomping, "I hate this."

Age 8

WHAT IS COMMON

Arguing, rudeness, getting even, holding grudges. Anger often covers embarrassment or hurt.

WHEN TO LOOK CLOSER

Eye-rolling, tense jaw, going quiet, sharp tone.

PART 2

Why it happens

THE SURPRISING PART

Many "bad behavior" explosions start in the body, not in the mind.

In a study of 1,490 preschoolers, 60% had a tantrum in the past month when tired, hungry or sick. That is almost as many as when frustrated (61%). Only about 1 in 4 had one that came "out of the blue". So before any lesson about kindness, check the basics: sleep, a snack, and a warning before changes.

Source: Wakschlag et al., 2012

Three common myths

MANY PARENTS THINK

"If I don't punish hitting hard, he'll keep doing it."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

Harsh punishment backfires. A review of five decades of research, with more than 160,000 children, linked spanking to more aggression and defiance.

MANY PARENTS THINK

"Tantrums mean I'm doing something wrong."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

More than 80% of preschoolers had a tantrum in the past month. What matters is how often, how long, and how destructive they are.

MANY PARENTS THINK

"I need to talk him out of it right now."

WHAT RESEARCH SHOWS

When the band is red, the thinking brain is offline. Naming the feeling calms the brain's alarm. Talk and fix later, when your child is green again.

Source: Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor, 2016 · NIMH, 2012 · Lieberman et al., 2007

What's underneath

The hitting is the tip. What drives it usually sits below the surface, and that is where the lasting fixes are.

WHAT YOU SEE

Hitting shouting throwing

Body needs

Tired, hungry or unwell children have much less patience. In a small study, toddlers who missed their nap reacted more negatively and showed less joy. Check sleep and snacks before anything else.

Source: Berger et al., 2012

Missing skills

Many children do not yet have words like "frustrated" or "jealous", or a plan for what to do instead. When words fail, hands take over.

Tricky moments

Losing, transitions (screens off, bedtime), being told no, and siblings are the classic triggers. Brothers and sisters close in age clash most because they compete for the same things.

Home climate

Stress, arguments, a new baby or a move fill a child's "cup" before the day even starts. Family stress and harsh parenting made high aggression more likely.

Source: Tremblay et al., 2004

What works

If hitting gets the toy, or a big reaction, the brain learns it works. Calm, predictable responses make it stop "paying off".

Feelings underneath

Anger is often a bodyguard for softer feelings: fear, sadness, jealousy, feeling left out. Ask: "What was the feeling before the mad?"

What makes it worse

Spanking and shouting make it worse. A review of five decades of research, covering more than 160,000 children, linked spanking to more aggression and defiance, with harmful links in 13 of 17 outcomes studied. The American Academy of Pediatrics advises against spanking and harsh words such as shaming.

Source: Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor, 2016 · AAP, 2018

PART 3

In the moment: Stay, Safe, Say, Solve

When the band is red, your child's thinking brain is offline. Lectures cannot land yet. Your only jobs are safety and calm.



1 **Stay calm**
Your calm is contagious. Lower your voice and get down to their level. Take three breaths yourself first.

2 **Keep it safe**
Gently block hits, move a sibling away, put thrown things out of reach. Say calmly: "I won't let you hit."

3 **Say the feeling**
"You're SO mad the tower fell." Naming a feeling calms the brain's alarm.

4 **Solve later**
Wait until they are green again. Then talk, fix and practice.

Why naming helps: in a brain-imaging study, putting feelings into words reduced activity in the amygdala, the brain's alarm center (Lieberman et al., 2007).

What to say

SAY	INSTEAD OF
"You're really mad. I'm right here."	"Stop crying right now."
"I won't let you hit. You can stomp or squeeze this pillow."	"You're a bad boy."
"Your band's going yellow. Power Word time?"	"Calm DOWN!"
"When you're ready, I'll help you."	"Go to your room until you can behave."
"Let's fix it together."	"Say sorry NOW."

After the storm: the 4 Rs

Reconnect

A hug, a glass of water, sitting together. Connection first.

Rewind

"What happened? What was the feeling?" Listen more than you talk.

Repair

Help them fix it: rebuild the tower, check on the sibling, say sorry when they mean it.

Rehearse

Act out the do-over, like the last page of the story.

PART 4

Every day, when everyone is calm

Most of the change happens between outbursts, not during them. Small daily habits work better than big reactions.

10 minutes of special time

Every day, let your child lead a game. Describe what they do and praise it. No questions, no instructions, no phones. It fills their cup and makes your limits easier to accept.

Catch the calm

Praise the exact moment: "You were mad and you used words. That was strong." Notice good moments far more often than you correct.

Warn before changes

"Five more minutes, then bath." Transitions are top triggers, and a warning gives the brain time to switch.

Few rules, said positively

"Hands are for helping." Follow through calmly and the same way each time. Consistency matters more than strictness.

Show your own cool-down

Say it out loud: "I'm frustrated. I'm going to take three breaths." Children copy what they see far more than what they hear.

Protect sleep and snacks

Regular bedtimes and a snack before hard moments (after school, before homework) prevent many storms.

This approach is proven

Parenting programs built on daily positive play, specific praise and calm, clear limits reduce children's disruptive behavior. Across 50 studies of one such program, families seeking help saw a moderate drop in problem behavior (effect size 0.50).

Source: Menting et al., 2013

PART 5

Seven activities that work

Each one takes a few minutes, uses things you already have, and practices one part of the Combo. Do them when everyone is calm.



Band Check-In

Ages 4–8 · 2 min a day · The band chart

1. Each evening, your child colors the band chart: green, yellow or red for today.
2. Ask about one yellow or red moment: "What happened? What helped?"
3. Finish with one green moment you noticed.

Why it works: Children can only stop what they notice. Daily naming builds that early-warning sense.

Soup Breaths

Ages 4–8 · 1 min · Nothing

1. Pretend to hold a bowl of hot soup.
2. Smell it slowly through your nose.
3. Blow on it, long and slow, to cool it. Three times.
4. For little ones: blow a tissue across the table to see a long breath.

Why it works: Long, slow breaths out settle a racing body. Practicing when calm makes the breath ready when mad.

Turtle Shell

Ages 4–6 · 5 min · A blanket

1. Notice the feeling: "My band is yellow."
2. Stop your body: freeze.
3. Tuck into your "shell" under the blanket and take three breaths.
4. Come out when calm and think of a solution together.

Why it works: This is the Turtle Technique, used in early-childhood programs to teach exactly these steps (NCPMI).

Body Clue Map

Ages 5–8 · 15 min · Big paper, markers

1. Trace around your child lying on the paper.
2. Ask: "Where do you feel mad in your body?" Color those spots red.
3. Write the clues next to them: hot face, tight fists, loud voice.
4. Hang it up, and point to it when you see a clue.

Why it works: Body clues come before the hit. Spotting them early is step 1 of the Combo.

Calm Corner

Ages 4–8 · 20 min to set up · Cushion, squeeze ball, Combo card

1. Build a cozy spot together: cushion, something to squeeze, the Combo card, a book, paper to scribble on.
2. Practice going there when calm, like a fire drill.
3. When the band goes yellow, offer it as a choice, never as a punishment.

Why it works: It gives angry energy a safe outlet and gives your child back a sense of control.

Replay Theater

Ages 4–8 · 10 min · Toys or blocks

1. Act out a real blow-up with toys. Let your child direct.
2. Play the "red" ending first. Laugh at how badly it goes.
3. Hit REPLAY and play the "green" ending using the Combo.

Why it works: Rehearsing a new response while calm makes it easier to reach for under stress. It is the same idea as the story's last page.

Trigger Detective (for you)

Parents · 1 week · Notebook or phone notes

1. After each outburst, note the time, what happened just before, and whether your child was tired or hungry.
2. After a week, look for patterns: same time, same activity, same person?
3. Change one thing: an earlier snack, a warning before screens go off.

Why it works: It shows you the iceberg. Many outbursts can be prevented, not just managed.

PART 6

Using your child's GTales story



Before

Read it at a calm time, like bedtime or a quiet afternoon. Never in the middle of a meltdown. Point to the band and show what green, yellow and red mean.

While reading

Pause on every "Your turn" and let your child answer, even the wrong answers: the funny result shows cause and effect. Ask, "What color is the band now?" Do the Combo with the hero on page 12.

After

Ask: "What made the band turn red? How did the hero help Wrecks?" Practice the Combo together and put the Combo card on the fridge.

Your 7-day plan

Day 1	Read together. Your child picks a Power Word.
Day 2	Practice the Combo as a game, when calm.
Day 3	Make a Body Clue Map.
Day 4	Re-read. Spot the band colors.
Day 5	Replay Theater with blocks.
Day 6	Build the Calm Corner.
Day 7	Celebrate. Talk about one time the Combo worked.

✂ CUT OUT AND KEEP ON THE FRIDGE

When the band turns red

1. Freeze and hug your tummy.
2. Three slow breaths.
3. Say your Power Word.
4. "I'm mad. I need…"

What grown-ups can say

- "You're really mad. I'm right here."
- "I won't let you hit."
- "When you're ready, I'll help you."

PART 7

When to get extra help

Most children get better with time, practice and calm support. Talk to a professional if you notice any of these:

- Tantrums or aggression on most days, especially after age 5.
- Often breaking things or hurting people or animals.
- Outbursts that come "out of the blue" or last a very long time.
- It happens with teachers and other adults too, not just at home.
- Your child hurts themselves or talks about hurting themselves.
- No improvement after several weeks of consistent practice.
- Big changes in sleep, eating or mood, or the school is worried.

Start with your pediatrician or the school counselor. A child psychologist can offer proven parent-coaching programs such as Parent-Child Interaction Therapy or Incredible Years.

Asking for help is a strong parenting move, not a failure.

Sources

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